

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

BANGLE DIPLOMACY

Every year, Union finance minister **Nirmala Sitharaman** hosts an informal luncheon for female journalists at her residence to celebrate Varalakshmi puja, to invoke goddess Lakshmi's blessings. This year, the event happened in mid-October and featured a special Navaratri spread along with north and south Indian delicacies. Attendees could not help noticing how the meal and decor were noticeably more extravagant than in previous years (there was even a display of oxidised jewellery and a traditional lac bangle maker from Rajasthan). If there was any cause for complaint, it was the seeming hierarchy at the lunch tables. The FM spent a majority of her time with the senior members of the community, even returning to their table to check their selections from the jewellery and bangles on offer. That said, the usually commanding FM was at her convivial best at the lunch.



An Unholy Handout

With all his current troubles, ex-Andhra CM **Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy** could sure do with some advice. But does he really have to pay so high a *gurudakshina* for it? Turns out Jagan allegedly handed out 15 acres of prime land to his spiritual advisor Swamy Swaroopanandendra of the Visakha Sarada Peetham at Bheemili, north of Visakhapatnam, for Rs 1 lakh per acre when its market value is at least Rs 1 crore per acre. With new CM Chandrababu Naidu eager to "expose" his predecessor's "misdeeds", expect another investigation.

Kaushik Deka with Sonal Khetarpal, Rohit Parihar, Ashish Misra, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Ajay Sukumaran and Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

ON SCREEN, OFF SCREEN

Maharashtra CM **Eknath Shinde** has been flexing his movie muscles with the two-part film *Dharmaveer*, using it to boost both his own image and that of his late mentor, Thane's Shiv Sena strongman Anand Dighe. Now, **Raj Thackeray** seems to be following suit. The Marathi movie *Yek Number* features a love-struck protagonist trying to meet the Maharashtra Navnirman Sena chief to impress his girlfriend, alongside clips of the MNS leader's fiery speeches. Meanwhile, Karnataka deputy CM **D.K. Shivakumar** claims he hasn't watched a movie in 25 years, despite once running cinema halls in the 1980s. Guess some prefer starring in the political drama rather than watching it.







Sabse Tej



Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav's nephew and Lalu Prasad Yadav's son-in-law, **Tej Pratap Yadav**, seems to be the party's go-to candidate—at least for now—for the Karhal assembly bypoll in Uttar Pradesh. This, by the way, is his third nomination this year after being 'swapped' at the last minute in the Rampur and Kannauj LS seats in the general election. Now, Karhal is his latest shot at political redemption after Akhilesh vacated it (he is now the Kannauj MP). Tej Pratap has been around since 2004, and has won several local elections, even bagging the Mainpuri Lok Sabha seat in 2014. Will it be third time lucky for Tej Pratap in 2024? Stay tuned.

SAFFRON SCRUB

The BJP's "washing machine" is at work again. The latest to come out of it scrubbed clean of all dirt stains is engineer/contractor Anoop Bartaria, who was part of Rajasthan CM **Bhajan Lal Sharma's** Bharatpur tour on October 11, and later announced on social media that he had been entrusted with transforming the town into a world-class city. Bartaria was earlier chargesheeted by the central investigative agencies, the CBI and ED, in a bank fraud case and is also the man at the heart of the Rs 5,500 crore Kota town beautification venture which had become the bane of the former Ashok Gehlot-led Congress government. PM Narendra Modi had even promised an inquiry into it during his poll yatras, while Union minister Gajendra Shekhawat was shocked at the "lavish spending". Apparently, all 'misgivings' have been cleared now.



PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR